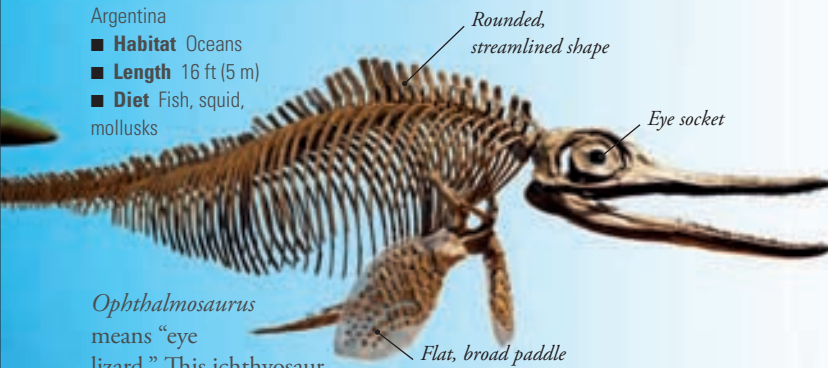




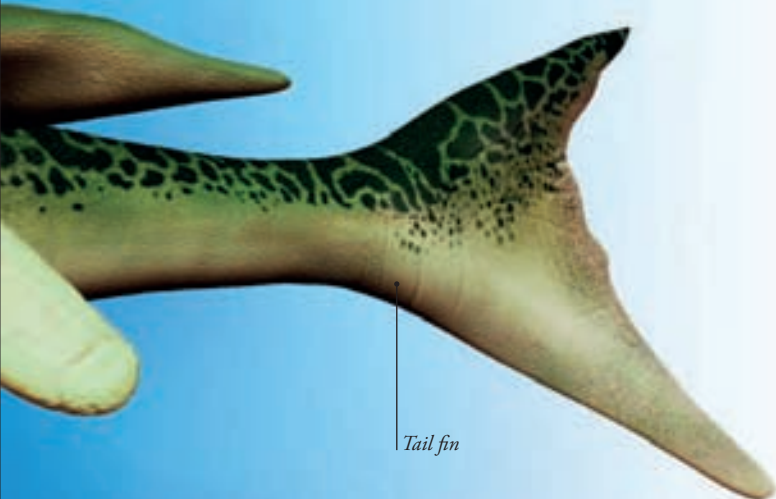
Ophthalmosaurus

off-THAL-mo-SORE-uss

- **When** 165–150 million years ago (Late Jurassic)
- **Fossil location** Europe, N. America, Argentina
- **Habitat** Oceans
- **Length** 16 ft (5 m)
- **Diet** Fish, squid, mollusks



Ophthalmosaurus means “eye lizard.” This ichthyosaur had the largest eyes relative to body size of any prehistoric animal. The eyes were as big as grapefruits and almost filled the skull. *Ophthalmosaurus* could probably see well in the dark and may have used its extraordinary vision to hunt in the depths of the sea. If so, it must also have been good at holding its breath for long periods on its trips into the deep.



Tail fin

Mixosaurus

MIX-oh-SORE-uss

- **When** 230 million years ago (Middle Triassic)
- **Fossil location** N. America, Europe, Asia
- **Habitat** Oceans
- **Length** Up to 3 ft 3 in (1 m)
- **Diet** Fish

Mixosaurus was one of the smallest ichthyosaurs. It swam by beating its tail from side to side, perhaps using bursts of speed to take shoals of fish by surprise. It caught prey in a long, narrow snout, which was lined with sharp teeth. Fossils of *Mixosaurus* have been found all over the world, indicating that the species lived throughout the oceans.

Ichthyosaurus

ICK-thee-oh-SORE-uss

- **When** 190 million years ago (Early Jurassic)
- **Fossil location** British Isles, Belgium, Germany
- **Habitat** Oceans
- **Length** 6 ft (1.8 m) long
- **Diet** Fish

Ichthyosaurus was a small, slim-snouted ichthyosaur. It had dozens of sharp, needlelike teeth and used them to catch squid or other kinds of mollusks. Studies of the ear bones of *Ichthyosaurus* show that it didn't have the highly sensitive hearing that dolphins have and couldn't detect objects in the water by using echoes (echolocation).

